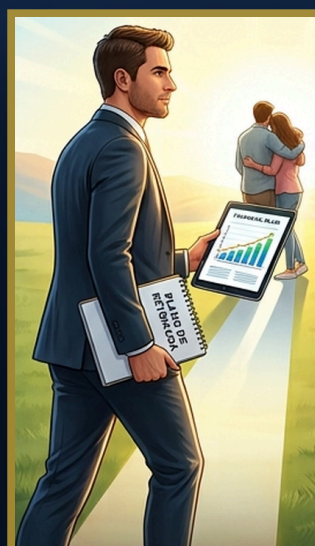
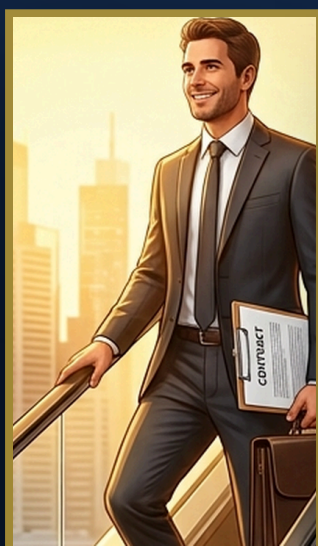


— A TRUE STORY —

# RISE, FALL, AND COMEBACK



## PART 1 • THE STORY

From the pharmacy stockroom to the top in sales.  
From the silence of hidden debt to a family recovery plan.

WRITTEN BY

JOSÉ RODRIGO

# **RISE, FALL, AND COMEBACK**

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Part 1 — The Story

From the pharmacy stockroom to the top in sales. From the silence of hidden debt to a family recovery plan.

**JOSÉ RODRIGO**

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This is a true story. Some names of people and companies have been changed to protect the privacy of those involved.

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## PROLOGUE

# The Man in the Mirror

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**A**t 50 years old, if you looked at my life from the outside, you would see the exact portrait of success. You would see a man who built a solid career in the pharmaceutical industry, working as a sales representative for one of the largest companies in Brazil. You would see a respected professional in the market of Paraíba, in the Brazilian Northeast, with average earnings above R\$ 20,000 a month (about US\$ 3,700) — a financial reality most Brazilians would not even dare to dream of.

You would see a happily married husband, father of two incredible girls — Maria Eduarda and Maria Júlia —, living in a comfortable, well-built home. The perfect picture of a provider who made it in life.

But what the spotlight of commercial success does not show is the silent shadow that lives in my mind when I close my bedroom door at night.

Behind the Suprema Laboratories badge and the wide smile in high-volume negotiations, there is a man being crushed by a mountain of debt he did not create for himself. Debt born not of incompetence, but of one of the noblest and most dangerous feelings a human being can have: **blind trust in friends**.

Today, my biggest contract is not with any large distributor. My greatest challenge is the daily fight against silence. I hide from the woman of my life the real size of the financial abyss I was dragged into for trying to help someone I considered a brother. Money comes in abundantly every month, but it drains away through the invisible pipes of loans, loan sharks, and guarantees I signed to cover other people's irresponsibility.

I came to think the unthinkable. I tasted the bitterness of absolute despair. But I am, before any corporate title, a survivor. And I have decided that my story will not end in a financial hole or in the end of my marriage.

This book is my confession, my escape map, and my greatest sales project. I will show you how I went from absolute scarcity to the top of the market, how I fell into the trap of leverage and false friendship, and, above all, what the real plan is to take back the reins of my life.

If you have ever trusted too much, if you have ever hidden a problem for fear of disappointing the ones you love, or if you need strength to rebuild everything from zero, sit down. **This story is for you.**

## Hunger and the Concrete Roof

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To understand the pain of almost losing everything, you first need to understand where I came from. My story did not begin in air-conditioned meeting rooms. It began in the harshest scarcity a family can face.

I was born in the small town of Boa Vista, in the countryside of Paraíba, Brazil. At four years old, we moved to the city of Campina Grande, hoping for better days. My father was transferred there for work, and my mother, a tireless warrior, earned our living at the sewing machine. We lived in a rented house, and life always operated at the edge of survival.

The problem is that the little we had frequently drained away through a painful hole. My father was a hardworking man, but he struggled with alcoholism. When drinking took over, he would spend months consumed by the addiction, spending what we did not have, oblivious to any responsibility at home. My mother held everything together alone, sewing day and night to put food on the table, but the mathematics of poverty is unforgiving.

I saw the electricity being cut off. I saw the water dry up in the taps because we had to choose between paying the bills or putting a plate of food on the table. I remember waking up in the middle of the night to find my mother crying, desperate, because there was absolutely nothing for our breakfast.

But hunger teaches. **Hunger shapes character in a way no university can imitate.**

One of the strongest images of my life, one I still carry today as a trophy of humility, is the chicken skin. On those rare occasions when we managed to buy a whole chicken, my mother, with an instinctive wisdom of survival, would remove the skin and store it with extreme care in the refrigerator. Days later, when the pantry emptied again, she would roast those skins. That simple dish, seasoned with my mother's love and sweat, was our banquet. And, in all the sincerity of the world, it was delicious.

My brothers, Rodinelly and Rodinelson, and I grew up in that scenario, studying in public schools and understanding very early that no one was coming to save us. The sense of responsibility knocked on my door brutally.

At 16, I decided that my mother would never again cry at dawn for lack of food — at least not if it depended on me. I went to work. My first official job was at Foto Matriz, a traditional photography shop in Campina Grande, thanks to a recommendation from my uncle Luiz and aunt Amanda. I was paid weekly. The feeling of taking that hard-earned money on a Saturday, stopping at the supermarket, and coming home with full bags was priceless. I was not just buying groceries; **I was buying my family's dignity.**

From there, I went to work at a high-turnover hotel. I cleaned, tidied up, saw everything. But the true endurance test came later, when I got a job at the Vulcano Factory, in the milling sector, where they made rubber sandals.

The routine was crushing. The alarm rang at 4 in the morning. The work was heavy, unhealthy, and drained every last drop of energy from my body. I would only get home in the middle of the afternoon, arms throbbing with exhaustion. It was there, feeling the weight of the world on my back on a production line, that a switch flipped in my head.

I was not afraid of hard work, but I understood that physical strength has a ceiling. If I truly wanted to change my family's destiny and fulfill the dream of pouring a concrete roof over our house — in Brazil, the ultimate symbol that a poor family is finally moving up —, I would need to use something beyond muscles. I needed to use intelligence. Destiny agreed with me, and my great school of sales was about to open its doors. The sign on the storefront read: **Master Drugstores**.

## CHAPTER 2

# The Price of the Chair (From Stockroom to Contract)

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**T**hat exhausting rhythm I learned at the factory prepared me for what came next. My true professional school, where the seed of the salesman began to sprout, had a name and an address: Master Drugstores, the largest pharmacy chain in Paraíba.

My first badge there had no glamour at all. I was the stockroom guy. My routine was divided between carrying boxes, organizing shelves, running errands at the bank, and hauling merchandise from one store to another by hand. It was work invisible to the customer's eyes, but it kept the gears turning. I tried to balance that routine with school, but exhaustion and the immediate need to bring money home spoke louder, and the diploma was left by the roadside.

As time passed, my effort was noticed and I was transferred to another store with the title of "store inspector." In practice, the stockroom had never left me. I was the do-it-all guy: I mopped the floor, arranged the shelves, and ran to fetch merchandise from another store whenever something was missing for a customer. However, being on the main floor changed my perspective. I began to watch the counter. I saw how the salesmen carried themselves, how they solved problems and, above all, how they made money.

That is where I decided to make my first great strategic leap.

I began cultivating a good relationship with the store manager. I delivered my manual work with excellence to earn his trust and, when I felt I had built that credit, I asked for an opportunity to learn how to sell medicines. He accepted, but the trial by fire came with a non-negotiable condition: I had to work my normal business hours, doing all the heavy lifting, go home, have a quick dinner, and return to the pharmacy at night — without earning any overtime.

**That was my toll.** On the night shift, I became the shadow of the late Mr. Jonas, a veteran who knew everything about medicines and customer service. I watched every move, memorized active ingredients, and absorbed all his experience. The routine became brutal. Every day, I stayed behind that counter until 11 at night. When the clerks wanted a weekend off, they paid me to cover their shifts. I accepted every one. Those double shifts were my true university.

Finally, I was promoted to the counter. But restlessness soon knocked. Selling boxes of medicine at retail, one by one, no longer satisfied me. I wanted volume. **I wanted scale.**

I decided to aim at the city governments and hospitals of Campina Grande. I took over a department at Master focused on public procurement bids which, at the time, limped along with sales of 10 to 12 thousand reais a month (about US\$ 2,000). I applied the same hunger I had on the factory floor and, in a short time, drove that department to revenues above 250 thousand reais a month (about US\$ 46,000). I had discovered my true talent: corporate sales (B2B).

I stayed at Master for almost five years. There, I forged my commercial foundation, but the biggest contract and greatest gift of my life did not come in the form of commission. It was there that I met Vivian, my wife. The woman who would stand by my side through the highest flights and the hardest falls.

With my experience in public bids, I moved to Alliance Drugstores, working in the same format. The commissions remained excellent, but the urge to build my own business spoke louder. With money coming in well, I opened a LAN house — an internet café with gaming computers, a booming business in Brazil at the time. It seemed like the perfect bet, until technology advanced cruelly, the internet reached people's homes, and the movement plummeted. I found myself hugging an obsolete business and a considerable debt from the financed equipment.

That was my first shock with financial risk. But despair does not pay bills. I swallowed my pride and went to do what I knew best: work relentlessly. With a lot of sweat in sales, I paid off that debt quickly. The lesson remained, but little did I know that destiny would still test my ability to handle debt in an infinitely heavier way.

## CHAPTER 3

# The Bluff and the Building of an Empire

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**D**espite the stumbles, the family foundation was always my greatest fuel. My brothers and I worked hard and, together, we managed to fulfill one of our mother's biggest dreams: pouring the concrete roof over our house. That slab of concrete was the material proof that misery had been left behind.

With the LAN house debts overcome, my eyes turned to my true professional target. I had always nurtured the desire to join the pharmaceutical industry. The path opened through Welson, a great friend and mentor who had already taught me a lot back in my pharmacy days. He told me about an opening for pharmacy sales visits as an independent sales representative at VitaMed Laboratories.

I went to the interview with the hunger of someone who needed that job. Everything was going well, until the manager asked a decisive question: **"Do you have a vehicle? What car do you drive?"**

I did not have a car. I only had a motorcycle. But the salesman who backs down loses the contract. I looked at him and answered with all the conviction in the world: "Yes, I do."

I was approved. I left celebrating, but with a giant logistical problem. I did not think twice: I sold my motorcycle, took on the financing of my first car, and started working. The courage paid off and sales flowed perfectly.

My performance put me on the competition's radar and I received simultaneous offers, choosing Apex Laboratories for the weight of being a multinational and the promise of the stability of a formal employment contract. I stayed three years there, but it was a challenging phase. The company was facing a severe crisis with logistics operators in Paraiba. Products were missing and sales were collapsing. I started living practically on the base salary alone.

The financial weight was brutal, exactly at the time my first daughter, Maria Eduarda, was born. Vivian was in college and also working, but the budget was extremely tight. The arrival of a child transforms a man's mind, and seeing my family facing that bottleneck demanded a lot of faith and perseverance.

After three years of hardship, the promise of a transition to Suprema Laboratories appeared. The detail: I would have to give up the security of formal employment to become independent again, taking over the operation for the entire state of Paraiba. To many, it sounded like a step backwards. To me, **it was the breaking of chains.**

I took over the operation and today, after 13 years with the company, I state categorically: it was the best professional decision of my life. That supposed step backwards propelled me to the top. I built a solid client portfolio, gained scale, and positioned myself at a level very few reach, arriving at average earnings of R\$ 20,000 a month (about US\$ 3,700).

I had won. The empty refrigerator of my childhood was a distant memory. Vivian was taken care of, my daughters had comfort, and I was a professional of the highest value in the market. I had everything in my

hands. Until the moment excessive trust entered the scene.

## Intimate Enemies

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**R**eaching the level of earnings I achieved at Suprema allowed me to look at wider horizons. Every sales professional in the pharmaceutical business, at some point, dreams of being on the other side of the counter — not as an employee, but as an owner. With capital in hand and a strong desire to secure an even more solid future for my family, I decided to make that dream real: I opened my own pharmacy.

What was supposed to be the crowning of my career quickly turned into one of the darkest phases of my life.

My mistake was not strategic, financial, or commercial. **My mistake was in hiring.** I brought into my business three people in whom I placed my trust, and I paid a very expensive psychological price for it. After little more than a year of operation, I had to fire the pharmacist. In retaliation, she took an action that crossed every moral and professional line: she sued me under Brazil's Maria da Penha domestic-violence law, inventing an assault that never happened on the day of her dismissal.

Being accused of something so serious — as a family man, a husband, and a father of two girls — was a devastating blow. The mental toll of having to defend myself from a lie of that magnitude was something I had never experienced. But the truth is non-negotiable and does not bend. I faced the situation head-on, went to labor court, paid absolutely everything she was owed by law and, thank God, proved my complete innocence.

As if the scare was not enough, when the dust settled, the truth behind the scenes appeared: that same pharmacist was having an affair with one of the clerks I had also hired. Together, they had stolen a lot of merchandise, bleeding my inventory for months behind my back.

The human disappointment was gigantic. I survived the storm, healed the psychological wounds and, acting with the coldness business demands, sold the pharmacy. I managed to recover my initial investment and closed that chapter. However, destiny would show me that the lesson about trusting people too much had not yet been fully learned.

# Suicidal Leverage

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**W**ith the dark chapter of the pharmacy officially closed and the initial capital recovered, I decided to channel that money to where it really mattered: my family. I took the sum and did a beautiful renovation of our house. It was a way of materializing my effort and bringing more comfort to Vivian and the girls. Life, in a way, was back on track. My commissions at Suprema remained excellent and the money flowed naturally.

But constant financial success sometimes blinds us. When you have cash flow and credit, the "unmissable opportunities" start knocking at your door.

It was around that time that the market was flooded by investment companies offering astronomical, unreal returns, disguised as cryptocurrency operations. The siren song was too seductive. I decided to test the waters. My first move was to put R\$ 15,000 (about US\$ 2,800) into GoldVision Investments. My commercial instinct, which had saved me so many times, spoke up in time. In April of that year, I decided to withdraw all my capital and the profit. I escaped unharmed. When October came, the company's structure collapsed, payments stopped, and thousands of people lost everything.

I had escaped a gigantic financial shipwreck. That should have served as a definitive warning, but the feeling of having come out ahead gave me false confidence.

That is when I fell into the real trap. Empire Coins promised absurd returns. I decided to put R\$ 80,000 (about US\$ 15,000) into that operation.

My mistake was not just trusting their system; my mistake was grotesque in the origin of the money. Of those 80 thousand, only 20 thousand were mine. The other R\$ 60,000 I borrowed. The math in my head seemed infallible: the interest on the loan was much lower than the monthly return guaranteed by the company. I would make the money work for me and profit from the difference. **It was the perfect crime of getting rich quick.**

Until the courts froze the company.

From one day to the next, the house of cards collapsed. The monthly payments disappeared and my R\$ 80,000 became completely locked and inaccessible — a situation that drags on to this day. The brutal difference is that, while the investment money was frozen, the interest clock on the R\$ 60,000 I owed never stopped ticking. I was resilient. I swallowed hard, lifted my head, and kept working hard to cover that monthly hole. The weight was already heavy — but, ironically, that fall would prove to be just a rehearsal.

## The Weight of the Guarantee

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**T**he debt I took on to invest in Empire Coins had a lethal urgency: the R\$ 60,000 had not come from a traditional bank, but from a loan shark. When the scheme collapsed, the off-the-books interest kept running at an unpayable speed. To stop that bleeding, I made a drastic and immediate decision. I took my car, which was fully paid off, sold it, topped up the remaining amount, and settled the debt with the loan shark. I financed another vehicle — which I am still paying for today — and believed the worst of the storm had passed.

But the real knockout would not come from the financial market. It would come, once again, from excessive trust.

I have always been the kind of guy who likes to see others growing alongside me. The greatest example of that had a name: Otávio. To me, he was not just a market colleague; he was a brother. For years, I was his biggest supporter. I got him a job at LifeCare Distribution. Later, I opened the doors for him at VitaMed Laboratories and, finally, managed to bring him into a sales territory within Suprema Laboratories itself.

Our exchange of favors crossed the line of the acceptable. Driven by the desire to help, I became his guarantor so he could take merchandise directly from some of my own clients. The dynamic seemed under control: he took the products, turned them over, and paid. Until the day the cycle broke and he simply could no longer honor his commitments.

The despair that hit me was not only financial; it was a paralyzing professional terror. **I was the guarantor.** My name was on the line with my clients, and my greatest fear was that this default would leak and reach the ears of Suprema's board. I had built an impeccable reputation over years at the company. The possibility of losing my job because of someone else's irresponsibility began to devour me from the inside.

To protect my job and my name, I had no choice: I took on his entire debt with the clients.

## The Labyrinth of Silence

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**T**hat was the moment the house of cards collapsed inside my own home. To cover this new and gigantic hole, I entered a labyrinth of omissions with the woman of my life. The first crack in our trust had already happened when I lied to Vivian, saying the loan for the failed investment had been only R\$ 30,000 (about US\$ 5,500), hiding the real depth of the hole. But the desperate need to pay Otávio's debts pushed me into an extreme move: I had to refinance my wife's car.

### **That was the first great seismic shock in our marriage.**

The domino effect was immediate. Financial mathematics has no feelings. I took out loans on my personal account, maxed out credit card limits, and shouldered a mountain of debt alone. The moment came when the equation simply did not close: I paid one creditor and was forced to leave another aside.

I began to carry the world on my back. The pain of being financially betrayed by someone I considered a brother pushed me to the edge of sanity. Anger and helplessness corroded me in such a way that, in moments of pure despair, I came to consider the worst. I thought about doing something insane. I thought about giving up on my own life.

But my faith in God spoke louder than the abyss. I would look at Vivian, at Duda, and at Maria Júlia, and I knew I could not give up. I pushed the shadows away from my mind, but the price charged was silence. While I kept up the pose of the strong provider husband, inside I felt like an absolute failure. The money came in, but drained away through the pipes of interest. The success I conquered on the street became a silent captivity inside my own mind.

## CHAPTER 8

# The Comeback and the Promise

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**S**adness tried to dominate me, but my will to win has always been greater. I decided that I will only rest the day my name is completely clean and peace reigns in my home. For that, I activated survival mode and went on the attack.

I knew I needed new sources of income. While maintaining my high performance at Suprema Laboratories, I decided to expand my commercial vision. I acquired a franchise and began working with solar energy by subscription, connecting clients to a business model that also involves mobile phone plans and vehicle insurance. I do not know where I find the strength to manage so many work fronts at the same time, but the engine that drives me is no longer blind ambition; **it is the urgency of freedom.**

I am rebuilding my life brick by brick. But this time, I carry a purpose that goes far beyond commissions.

I write these pages not just as an outlet, but as a survival manual. My greatest desire is, in the near future, to have the courage to sit at a couples' retreat and tell all of this with my head held high. I want to look into the eyes of other men and women and warn them: never hide your financial crises from your partners. **Total transparency is the only salvation for a marriage.**

I fell because of blind trust. I paid the price of naivety. But I am rising again through the strength of my work and the grace of God. And, with absolute conviction, I declare: never again will I make the same mistakes. The rise taught me how to sell; the fall taught me whom not to trust; but it is the comeback that is forging the man I was born to be.

## THE STORY CONTINUES — AND SO DOES THE SOLUTION

You have just witnessed my fall. But knowing the pain is only half the journey.

In **Part 2 — The Survival and Comeback Manual**, I open my war plan with pencil and paper: the 5 financial mistakes you must never repeat, the Chaos Triage to organize your debts without panic, the step-by-step guide to the conversation that saves a marriage, and the B2B sales strategies I am using to accelerate my own comeback.

**If my story is your story, the Manual is your way out.**